feverish haste in the multiplication of banks does not in itself connote quality.'[13]

From its inception people had the impression that the Central Bank was a Parsi bank. No doubt, many of its employees were Parsis, and many members of the community took their custom to it. But apart from this preponderance of the Parsis in personnel and patrons at that time, there was nothing to suggest that there was any communal bias at the bank. Sorabji was aware of this when in February 1916, he observed: 'I should like to take this opportunity to correct a wrong impression that seems to be prevalent that our Bank is a Parsi Bank. We have three Parsis and three Hindu directors on the Board and quite recently we have been fortunate in obtaining the cooperation of a valued Mohammedan colleague in Mr Ajam. I assure you that the Bank is doing its business without distinction and with the confidence of all the varied communities of Bombay. We are particularly desirous and anxious to stand by the small Indian trader and business people and we are thereby carrying out one of the principle functions of a Swadeshi Bank.'[14]

However the Parsi connection was and still is very strong. N.M. Mistry who served the bank for thirty-five years before retiring as the Chairman and Managing Director (1990–91) recalls that the Central Bank was like one big Parsi family where everybody looked after each other. They also fought but stood together when the need arose. If the ledger did not balance everyone pitched in.[15]

The bank's first branch was opened in Mandvi on May 1, 1912. Other branches were opened at important business centres of the city such as Zaveri Bazaar, Share Bazaar, Abdul Rehman Street, Sandhurst Road, Kalbadevi, and Bhuleshwar. The first branch outside Mumbai opened in Karachi in August 1913. The Central Bank was well and truly away but it would face numerous threats to its existence, something which forms the subject of the next Chapter.